United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization

Intangible Cultural Heritage

Interviewing in inventorying

Unit 25 PowerPoint presentation

UNESCO
Intangible Cultural Heritage Section

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In this presentation …

- Exploring and documenting experiences and knowledge
- Preparing for the interview
- Interviewing styles
- Interviewing techniques

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Preparing for the interview

- A good interview is like a good conversation.
- Understand the topic of discussion.
- Draft preliminary questions.

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Making initial contact

- Explain the purpose to potential interviewees.

- Inform potential interviewees of:
  - information about the inventory
  - how long the interview will last
  - where it will take place
  - who will be present, and
  - what will be expected of the interviewee.

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Equipment

- Types of possible equipment:
  - audio recorders,
  - microphones, and
  - video cameras.

- Interviewers should:
  - learn the basics of using the equipment,
  - ensure that the batteries are fully charged,
  - check that the device is recording throughout the interview.

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Choosing a location

Choose a location:

•Free of distractions and

•Easily accessible for the interviewee.

Ask interviewees where they would feel most comfortable.

Avoid background noise.

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Setting up the interview

- Position the recording device.
- Seat the interviewee:
  - Is there a door that may open?
  - Are there open windows?
  - Is there an audible television or radio?
  - Are there any other devices nearby that may detract from the quality of the recording?
- Balance sound quality with the comfort of the interviewee.

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Asking questions

Good questions	Bad questions
• Inspire discussion, • Generate important and interesting information about the ICH element, • Flow naturally with the conversation, and • Make the interviewee feel comfortable and at ease.	• Don't provide insight about the ICH element, • Can upset the interviewees or make them feel awkward, • Will disengage the interviewee, and • Can disrupt the flow of conversation.

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What, where, who, how, why and when

- These questions provide a formula for getting the full story.
- What types of information are sought?
- Ask questions that will produce the most information about the ICH element

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Open-ended vs. closed questions

- Open-ended:
  - cannot be answered with a ‘yes’ or ‘no’,
  - are more conversational, and
  - can help an interviewee to open up.

- Closed:
  - can be answered with a ‘yes’ or ‘no’,
  - provide specific information, and
  - can help warm up an interviewee at the outset.

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Wording of questions

- The wording of questions shapes the way an interviewee will answer
- Use neutral phrasing
- Avoid leading questions
- As questions one at a time in a manner
- Use ‘why’ questions with caution

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Active listening

Refers to the way the interviewer listens to and interacts with the interviewee.

- Active listening is achieved by:
  - facing the interviewee,
  - maintaining eye contact,
  - responding appropriately,
  - focusing on what is being said,
  - keeping an open mind,
  - avoiding personal opinions, and
  - not interrupting.

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Acknowledging answers

- Acknowledging answers can be distracting and will be heard on the final recording.
- They should be timely and kept to a minimum.
- Try to use non-verbal cues:
  - head nodding,
  - smiling, and
  - eye contact.

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Paraphrasing

- Paraphrasing is restatement in the interviewer's own words.
- It shows understanding.
- It should be done in a timely manner.
- Do not interrupt the interviewee.

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Concluding the interview

- Is there anything you would like to add?
- Review your notes for unasked questions.
- Wrap up the interview.
- Thank the respondent.

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Published in 2016 by the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization, 7, place de Fontenoy, 75352 Paris 07 SP, France

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